THE OPERATOR'S TOOLKIT · WEDNESDAY 3

How long is your lunch queue really waiting?

Two counts at 12:10 give you the wait, what walks out, and the fix.



SWIPE FOR THE COUNT

STEP 1

Count the queue at 12:10

Every order waiting to order or pay, at exactly ten past twelve. A group paying together is one order.

SITE 10, THE EXAMPLE FROM MONDAY

In the queue at 12:10	12

Count on three different days and take the average. One busy Friday isn't your lunch.

STEP 2

Count what the till serves

From 12:10, count the orders completed at the till for five minutes. Divide by five.

SITE 10

Served from 12:10 to 12:15	10
Served a minute (10 ÷ 5)	**2**

Count at the till, not the door. If your till reports orders by the minute, it has already counted for you.

STEP 3

Divide one by the other

The queue, divided by how fast you serve, is how long the last person waits.

$$12 \div 2$$

$$= 6 \text{ minutes}$$

That's Little's Law, proved by John Little in 1961, turned round. It holds while the till is busy and the queue isn't growing: lunch, in other words.

STEP 4

Price what walks out

Ask whoever is nearest the door to tally the guests who join and leave, or look and walk on.

SITE 10

Walk-aways a day	10
× average lunch spend	£8.50
× lunch days a week	6
Lost a week	£510

SITE 10 is £520 a week short of break-even. Its lunch queue is costing it £510.

STEP 5

Work out the speed you need

Pick the longest wait you'd accept as a guest. Divide the queue by it.

SITE 10, TARGET WAIT 4 MINUTES

12 ÷ 4	3 a minute
Today it serves	2 a minute

Not more staff all day. One more serve a minute, between 12:00 and 13:00.

Look first at the person doing two jobs: taking orders and making drinks.

YOUR SITE

Fill it in

A	**Queue at 12:10** orders, average of three days	_____
B	**Served a minute** orders from 12:10 to 12:15, ÷ 5	_____
C	**Wait** A ÷ B	_____ min
D	**Walk-aways a day**	_____
E	**Lost a week** D × lunch spend × lunch days	£ _____
F	**Target wait**	_____ min
G	**Served a minute needed** A ÷ F	_____

RUNNING MORE THAN ONE SITE?

Comment QUEUE for the multi-site version.

Every site's lunch peak side by side: the wait, the speed it needs, what walks out, ranked, with a guide to where the noon queue slows.

Watch Monday's episode of The Operator's Ledger, "Little's Law", on the WRW Hospitality page.

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